

The Ransom of Red Chief

O. Henry · 1907

First published: Saturday Evening Post, Jul 1907

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_ransom_of_Red_Chief_and_other_O._Henry_stories_for_boys/The_Ransom_Of_Red_Chief (revision 13357856), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about comic reversal?
- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about greed?
- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about childhood?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Ransom of Red Chief	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*comic reversal* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Ransom of Red Chief

Author biography

O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a sleepy Alabama town around 1900. O. Henry lived in the South and knew small-town con men; kidnapping for ransom was a feared crime in the period.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Saturday Evening Post on 6 July 1907; collected in Whirligigs (1910).

Then: Very popular and adapted into film several times.

Now: A comic classic for teaching verbal and situational irony and humorous first-person narration.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Two small-time crooks, Sam and Bill, kidnap the young son of a wealthy man and demand a $2,000 ransom.

Main themes

- irony and reversal.
- greed.
- comic chaos.

Why it matters

It shows how humor works through reversal and voice.

Spoilers · teacher only

The boy, who calls himself Red Chief, torments them so much that they end up paying the father $250 to take him back.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Ransom of Red Chief: Describe a plan that went hilariously wrong.
Prompt: Before we open The Ransom of Red Chief: Describe a plan that went hilariously wrong.

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

situational irony; verbal irony; hyperbole; diction; first-person narrator.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910. The world of the book. Set in a sleepy Alabama town around 1900. O. Henry lived in the South and knew small-town con men; kidnapping for ransom was a feared crime in the period. Publication and reception. First published in The Saturday Evening Post on 6 July 1907; collected in Whirligigs (1910). Then: Very popular and adapted into film several times. Now: A comic classic for teaching verbal and situational irony and humorous first-person narration.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). The opening.

> *It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). The opening.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Two small-time crooks, Sam and Bill, kidnap the young son of a wealthy man and demand a $2,000 ransom. Themes to track: irony and reversal.: greed.: comic chaos.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Ransom of Red Chief: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Ransom of Red Chief still matter? It shows how humor works through reversal and voice.
Anchor question: Why might The Ransom of Red Chief still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows how humor works through reversal and voice.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Who really holds power in this story? Answer: Red Chief; the kidnappers become the victims.
Exit ticket: Who really holds power in this story?
Answer: Red Chief; the kidnappers become the victims.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Ransom of Red Chief.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "O. Henry" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/O-Henry); NCpedia, "Porter, William Sydney (O. Henry)" (https://www.ncpedia.org/biography/porter-william-sydney); O. Henry Museum (Austin) (https://www.austintexas.gov/department/o-henry-museum)

Lesson 2: The Ransom of Red Chief

Focus: a crime that backfires

Content note (kidnapping played for comedy, dated stereotypes in a child playing "indian"): Sensitive content: Kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian". Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian".
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers pay and flee.

Background: Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang.

Significance: A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to irony and reversal because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian".
Prompt: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to irony and reversal because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: power shifts entirely to the child.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: dictating — issue commands or orders for; playmate — a companion at play; egotism — too much concern with oneself; patched — hastily put together; humiliating — cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of.
Words: dictating: issue commands or orders for · playmate: a companion at play · egotism: too much concern with oneself · patched: hastily put together · humiliating: cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang. A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary. Irony: The kidnappers pay the ransom. Diction / vocabulary: Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate. Hyperbole: Bill's sufferings are exaggerated for laughter. Watch for the ransom letter: the plan's pomposity, signed "Two Desperate Men."

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). Foreshadowing. That is irony at work: The kidnappers pay the ransom.

> *It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you* *(The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). Foreshadowing. That is irony at work: The kidnappers pay the ransom.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: "Desperate" is meant to sound dangerous, but by the end it means desperate to get rid of the boy. Ask: How does this line connect to irony and reversal? Expected: Power shifts entirely to the child. (The signature.)

> *Two Desperate Men* *(The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: "Desperate" is meant to sound dangerous, but by the end it means desperate to get rid of the boy.
Ask: How does this line connect to irony and reversal?
Expected answer: Power shifts entirely to the child. (The signature.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for irony, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. When the text says "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1), it shows this directly. Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand."

Task: Annotate the story for irony, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. When the text says "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1), it shows this directly. Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended? Ask: is Mr. Dorset a better con man than Sam?

Anchor question: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?

Facilitation: Ask: is Mr. Dorset a better con man than Sam?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. ("It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you", The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. ("It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you", The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how irony shapes a crime that backfires. Key takeaway: power shifts entirely to the child.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** The kidnappers pay the ransom.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate.
- **Hyperbole:** Bill's sufferings are exaggerated for laughter.

Themes and how they develop

- **irony and reversal:** power shifts entirely to the child.

Symbols and motifs

- **the ransom letter:** the plan's pomposity, signed "Two Desperate Men."

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1) Foreshadowing.
- “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56) The signature.
- “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95) The reversal.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits.
Evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1)
Reasoning: Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset’s hand."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
dictating (verb)	issue commands or orders for	*Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
playmate (noun)	a companion at play	*He's your playmate for the day.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

egotism (noun)	too much concern with oneself	*I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
patched (adjective)	hastily put together	*Itook the rock away from the boy and kind of patched up the argument. "I'll fix you," says the kid to Bill. "No man ever yet struck the Red Chief but what he got paid for it.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
humiliating (verb)	cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of	*They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
impudent (adjective)	marked by casual disrespect	*"Great pirates of Penzance!" says I; "of all the impudent——"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
vicinity (noun)	a surrounding or nearby region	*Iwent up on the peak of the little mountain and ran my eye over the contiguous vicinity.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
elevation (noun)	a lifting up; high spirits	*On the rear elevation of this mountain was a cave.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
accidents (noun)	an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury	*"No," says Bill, "nothing chronic except malaria and accidents.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
spending (verb)	pass time in a specific way	*His folks may think he's spending the night with Aunt Jane or one of the neighbours.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with comic reversal?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: To collect a ransom
2. What does the boy call himself? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Red Chief
3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He enjoys it as an adventure
4. What does the father propose? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back
5. Who suffers most from the boy's games? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Bill
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Ransom of Red Chief" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers pay and flee.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Ransom of Red Chief"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Ransom of Red Chief" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid." What does "dictating" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: dictating: issue commands or orders for.
10. Reread: "He's your playmate for the day." What does "playmate" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: playmate: a companion at play.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Ransom of Red Chief" suggest about a crime that backfires? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about a crime that backfires? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Ransom of Red Chief”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Ransom of Red Chief” set up that the rest of The Ransom of Red Chief will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with comic reversal? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. On diction / vocabulary: Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Ransom of Red Chief” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a crime that backfires? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Ransom of Red Chief”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to greed: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56):

The signature. On irony: The kidnappers pay the ransom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Ransom of Red Chief” treats a crime that backfires with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Ransom of Red Chief see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve comic reversal? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a crime that backfires? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy?

   A. To teach him a lesson

B. Because he is lost

C. To collect a ransom

D. To get revenge on his father

2. What does the boy call himself?

A. Red Chief

B. Chief Dorset

C. Old Hank

D. Black Scout

3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped?

A. He is terrified

B. He enjoys it as an adventure

C. He is bored

D. He tries to escape

4. What does the father propose?

A. He calls the sheriff

B. He refuses to answer

C. He pays double

D. The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back

5. Who suffers most from the boy's games?

A. Sam

B. Bill

C. The father

D. The sheriff

6. In the line “Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.”, what does “dictating” most nearly mean?

A. too much concern with oneself

B. hastily put together

C. issue commands or orders for

D. a companion at play

7. In the line “He's your playmate for the day.”, what does “playmate” most nearly mean?

A. hastily put together

B. too much concern with oneself

C. issue commands or orders for

D. a companion at play

Answer key: 1. C (To collect a ransom); 2. A (Red Chief); 3. B (He enjoys it as an adventure); 4. D (The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back); 5. B (Bill); 6. C (issue commands or orders for); 7. D (a companion at play)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Ransom of Red Chief," how does Henry show a crime that backfires? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): In The Ransom of Red Chief, how does Henry develop the idea of a crime that backfires? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a crime that backfires. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what The Ransom of Red Chief suggests about a crime that backfires. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in The Ransom of Red Chief to complicate the reader's understanding of a crime that backfires. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Ransom of Red Chief within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a crime that backfires responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Ransom of Red Chief alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a crime that backfires follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Ransom of Red Chief and its treatment of a crime that backfires. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Ransom of Red Chief as evidence for a larger claim about a crime that backfires in The Ransom of Red Chief. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Ransom of Red Chief as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a crime that backfires. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Ransom of Red Chief.

SAT-style questions

1. *I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “egotism” most nearly mean?

   A. too much concern with oneself

   B. pass time in a specific way

   C. a lifting up; high spirits

   D. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury

2. *Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill. They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars. It's an awful thing to hear a strong, desperate, fat man scream incontinently in a cave at daybreak.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Ransom of Red Chief”?

   A. The art of the deadpan tall tale

   B. A crime that backfires

   C. Wishes that defy fate

   D. A story told to protect a livelihood

SAT key: 1. A (too much concern with oneself); 2. B (A crime that backfires)

Whole-book test

The Ransom of Red Chief: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy?
   A. To teach him a lesson
   B. Because he is lost
   C. To collect a ransom
   D. To get revenge on his father
2. What does the boy call himself?
   A. Red Chief
   B. Chief Dorset
   C. Old Hank
   D. Black Scout
3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped?
   A. He is terrified
   B. He enjoys it as an adventure
   C. He is bored
   D. He tries to escape
4. What does the father propose?
   A. He calls the sheriff
   B. He refuses to answer
   C. He pays double
   D. The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back
5. Who suffers most from the boy's games?
   A. Sam
   B. Bill
   C. The father
   D. The sheriff
6. In the line “Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.”, what does “dictating” most nearly mean?
   A. too much concern with oneself
   B. hastily put together
   C. issue commands or orders for
   D. a companion at play

7. In the line “He's your playmate for the day.”, what does “playmate” most nearly mean?
   A. hastily put together
   B. too much concern with oneself
   C. issue commands or orders for
   D. a companion at play
8. As used in the story (“Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.”), what does “dictating” mean?
   A. issue commands or orders for
   B. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
   C. a lifting up; high spirits
   D. a companion at play
9. As used in the story (“He's your playmate for the day.”), what does “playmate” mean?
   A. marked by casual disrespect
   B. a companion at play
   C. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury
   D. too much concern with oneself
10. As used in the story (“I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance ”), what does “egotism” mean?
    A. a surrounding or nearby region
    B. pass time in a specific way
    C. too much concern with oneself
    D. hastily put together
11. As used in the story (“Itook the rock away from the boy and kind of patched up the argument. "I'll fix you," says the kid to Bill. "No man ever yet struck the Red ”), what does “patched” mean?
    A. a lifting up; high spirits
    B. issue commands or orders for
    C. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
    D. hastily put together
12. As used in the story (“They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecen”), what does “humiliating” mean?
    A. cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of
    B. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury
    C. a companion at play
    D. marked by casual disrespect

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how comic reversal develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how greed develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how childhood develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (comic reversal, greed, childhood) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (To collect a ransom); 2. A (Red Chief); 3. B (He enjoys it as an adventure); 4. D (The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back); 5. B (Bill); 6. C (issue commands or orders for); 7. D (a companion at play); 8. A (issue commands or orders for); 9. B (a companion at play); 10. C (too much concern with oneself); 11. D (hastily put together); 12. A (cause to feel shame; hurt the pride of)

Essay assignments

Essay: Comic reversal

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about comic reversal. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops comic reversal across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of comic reversal. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of comic reversal, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of comic reversal in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four

scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Greed

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about greed. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops greed across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of greed in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Childhood

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about childhood. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops childhood across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of childhood. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of childhood, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of childhood in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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